Henry Allan Gleason

Born in 1882, Henry Gleason studied biology at the University of Illinois. He held faculty posts and conducted acclaimed early ecological research in Sand Ridge State Forest, Illinois. In the 1920s, Gleason's theory of individualistic—rather than holistic—plant communities was not accepted by ecologists. This rejection led Gleason to abandon ecology in the 1930s. He had long held posts at the New York Botanical Garden and became famed for his work on plant classification. With botanist Arthur Cronquist, he co-wrote a definitive guide to the plants of the northeastern US. He retired in 1950 but continued to write and study. He died in 1975.

Key works

1922 "On the Relation between Species and Area"

1926 "The Individualistic Concept of the Plant Association"

See also: The ecosystem • The distribution of species over space and time • Ecological succession • Climax community • The ecological guild • Biomes